

The Fateful Adventures of the Good Soldiers: Loyalty, Desertion, and the Czechoslovak Legions

A Position Paper

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Abstract

Wartime desertion is typically studied in conscript armies, where staying may reflect fear rather than loyalty. This paper proposes to exploit the Czechoslovak Legions, a volunteer force formed from emigrants, prisoners of war, and Habsburg army deserters during World War I, as a cleaner setting for separating genuine commitment from coercion. The first part of the analysis examines what drove Czechoslovak soldiers to desert the Habsburg army and join the Legions, with nationalist identity as the mechanism of interest alongside those established in the existing literature. The second examines why some soldiers subsequently deserted the Legions themselves. Because enlistment was voluntary, this setting substantially reduces the initial coercion confound and allows a cleaner study of what sustained or weakened commitment. The study draws on two datasets totalling approximately 300,000 individual soldier records not previously used in economic research. More broadly, the findings could speak to the literature on organisational loyalty and identity, and the role of ideological motivation in sustaining commitment under high stakes.

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1 Introduction

The First World War drew nations across Europe, Asia, and beyond into a conflict of unprecedented duration and cost. As the war dragged on and the Central Powers began to lose ground, desertion rates rose across their armies, a pattern documented in the Hungarian army by Beneš (2017) and likely common across the alliance. A particular group of deserters, however, made a choice that set them apart from the rest. Rather than finding their peace away from the terrors of war, they chose to keep fighting on the other side. They joined the Czechoslovak Legions.

The Legions were formed in Russia, France, and Italy. At first, most of their members were Czechoslovak volunteers living in exile. As the war went on, they were joined by deserters from the Habsburg army (McNamara, 2016). Not only did the Legions serve as an important military force, they also played a notable role as a diplomatic lever that helped establish Czechoslovakia as an independent state after the war (McNamara, 2016).

This army of volunteers offers a unique research setting. The existing literature on desertion (Costa & Kahn, 2003; Dippel & Heblich, 2021; Fan et al., 2026; Ferrara, Dippel, & Heblich, 2025; Rozenas, Talibova, & Zhukov, 2024) focuses on conscripted or partially conscripted armies, where the decision to remain may reflect not loyalty but the fear of punishment for desertion. This confound is significantly reduced in the case of the Legions, as those who joined did so voluntarily, and their subsequent desertion may therefore reflect something other than the avoidance of coercion.

This paper proposes a study that would use data on more than 300,000 individuals, collected by the Central Military Archives of the Czech Republic (n.d.) and Czechoslovak Legionnaires' Association (n.d.), to examine two distinct desertion outcomes. The first is desertion from the Habsburg army into the Legions, and the second is subsequent desertion from the Legions themselves. For both, the study aims to identify the underlying determinants, controlling for the mechanisms established in the existing literature, while estimating the effect of nationalism and broader political views on the decision to desert.

The paper takes the position that the Legions offer a potentially cleaner setting for studying wartime desertion. The analysis of desertion from the Habsburg army examines whether nationalist identity drove soldiers to abandon imperial service, controlling for the mechanisms established in the existing literature. The analysis of desertion from the Legions exploits the voluntary nature of enlistment. Soldiers who left did so despite having already committed to the national cause, which substantially reduces the initial conscription confound present in studies of conscript armies. Nationalist and political identity could play a role here, too, though the primary contribution would be a cleaner identification of what kept soldiers in or drove them out.

The rest of this position paper is organised as follows. Section 2 presents the current state of research on desertion in various armies and its connection with broader literature. Subsequently, Section 3 elaborates on the historical role of the Legions and their formation. Finally, Section 4 summarises the methods used in core desertion studies and their potential for the proposed paper. Section 5 concludes.

2 Desertion, Leadership, and Recognition

The determinants of wartime desertion have attracted substantial attention in economic history, with recent work identifying individual and unit characteristics, political context, and leader quality as key predictors of soldier loyalty. Costa and Kahn (2003) use Union Army records from the United States (U.S.) Civil War to show that unit homogeneity reduces desertion, while Brufal and Ohler (2026) extend this finding to leaders, suggesting that shared regional origin between officers and soldiers raises fighting effort. Rozenas, Talibova, and Zhukov (2024) examine the role of political repression as a mechanism, finding that Soviet soldiers from more heavily repressed regions exhibit lower desertion rates during World War II.

Another branch of the literature explains desertion through leader quality. Dippel and Heblich (2021) study leaders expelled after the German Revolution of 1848–1849 who subsequently became antislavery campaigners in the U.S. and helped mobilise Union Army volunteers. They find that companies including these motivated soldiers exhibited lower desertion rates, with the effect strongest among unit captains. Similarly, Ferrara, Dippel, and Heblich (2025) use these Union Army records, covering 2.2 million soldiers, and find that captain quality significantly mitigated desertion in combat. Additionally, these leaders earned more on average after the war and were more frequently recognised positively in postwar records.

Fan et al. (2026) examine promotion incentives as a mechanism, using data on more than 2,800 high-ranking officers from the Second Sino-Japanese War (part of the Second World War). They find that officers with slower promotion rates desert more frequently, as do those who fall behind the promotion pace of their schoolmates and fellow townsmen. When previously deserted officers advance more quickly in the enemy army, their former peers desert at higher rates, suggesting that both internal and external recognition matter.

Recognition operates through similar channels beyond desertion. Ager et al. (2022) find that both victory rates and death rates increase among German World War II pilots after a fellow pilot receives public recognition, suggesting that peer comparisons drive risk-taking behaviour more broadly. The peer effect is further documented by Guo, Jackson, and Jia (2024), who analysed the allegiances of U.S. West Point cadets during the American Civil

War.

The desertion literature also connects to broader literature on individual behaviour under institutional and social pressure. Cahlíková and Cingl (2017) demonstrate that acute stress shifts risk preferences in experimental settings, while Heissel et al. (2018) find that chronic background stress deteriorates performance under high-stakes conditions through physiological responses.

Another related strand of the literature examines how the composition and behaviour of social networks shape major decisions under ideological or political pressure. Enikolopov, Makarin, and Petrova (2020) find that exposure to opposition media increases protest participation in Russia, while Cantoni et al. (2019) argue that patriotic education reduces it in China. García-Jimeno, Iglesias, and Yildirim (2018) document how female social networks determined the geographic spread of suffrage activism in the United States.

Finally, the listed desertion literature connects to broader research on leadership and organisational management. Akerlof and Kranton (2005) establish that worker identification with an organisation improves effort provision, and Ottinger and Voigtländer (2025) find that individual leaders have persistent causal effects on state performance. Giorcelli (2023) and Bianchi and Giorcelli (2022) provide further evidence on how managerial quality and organisational structure affect productivity.

Despite the recent growth of this literature, the role of nationalist identity as a mechanism driving desertion has received relatively little attention. A further limitation is that studies relying on conscript armies may be unable to cleanly separate loyalty from the absence of a credible exit option, as soldiers who do not desert may do so out of fear of punishment rather than genuine commitment.

The proposed paper addresses these gaps by using two related datasets (Central Military Archives of the Czech Republic, [n.d.](#); Czechoslovak Legionnaires' Association, [n.d.](#)). First, the analysis of Czechoslovak soldiers in the Habsburg Army examines desertion in a coercive military environment, where soldiers could remain in imperial service, desert, or join the Czechoslovak Legions. This setting makes it possible to study desertion not only as a response to military discipline, leadership, repression, or peer effects. Furthermore, it makes it possible to capture potential expression of political and national identification.

Second, the analysis of the Czechoslovak Legions focuses on more than 130,000 soldiers who had already voluntarily joined a nationalist military project. This setting makes it possible to examine why some soldiers deserted even after an initial voluntary commitment to the national cause. Together, the two datasets enable a distinction between nationalist motivation as a reason for leaving the Habsburg Army and the factors that weakened or limited this motivation within the Legions. The following section traces the formation of the Legions and their role in the conflict.

3 Czechoslovak Legions and Their Contribution

World War I turned into a conflict of unprecedented scale. As the struggle expanded, shirking and deserting became more common. Beneš (2017) documents a gradual rise in desertions from the Hungarian army across each year of the conflict, arguing that by the later stages of the war, desertion had gained a substantial political, social, and national character.

The national and political character of desertions led to the formation of the Czechoslovak Legions (Bednařík, 1927; Boháč, 1938; Vaněk & Holeček, 1925). As Czech and Slovak soldiers fought for an empire they disapproved of, many surrendered voluntarily to join the Allied side or simply deserted. Gradually, these men created an unusual military voluntary force, the Czechoslovak Legions.

Starting from 1914, the Legions became a part of the French and Russian Imperial armies (Bednařík, 1927; Vaněk & Holeček, 1925). By 1917, another division was independently formed in Italy (Boháč, 1938). Following the Russian Revolution, the Legions also played a notable role in the civil war, briefly controlling substantial portions of the Trans-Siberian Railway in their fights against the Bolsheviks (McNamara, 2016). Moreover, their war effort was important not only militarily but even politically, as the Legions served as a diplomatic lever that helped establish Czechoslovakia as an independent state after 1918 (McNamara, 2016).

The existing literature suggests that Czechoslovak soldier behaviour during World War I cannot be explained by national identity alone. Lein (2014) shows that the myth of Czechoslovak “general unreliability” had roots in prewar pan-German prejudice against Slavic soldiers. He argues that the narrative was later reinforced throughout the war by defeats of predominantly Czech units, such as the dissolutions of the 28th and 36th Infantry Regiments in 1915 or the controversies around the Brusilov Offensive and Zborov in 1916–17, as these breakdowns were blamed on treachery rather than command failures.

Cornwall (2000) and Hutečka (2019) reach similar conclusions, demonstrating that the collapse of military commitment was driven by structural conditions and individual experience rather than nationalist motivation. These studies, however, rely on qualitative and narrative methods that cannot systematically identify what distinguished those who deserted and joined the Legions from those who stayed and endured.

The Czechoslovak Legions remain an understudied setting. Hutečka (2023) argues that the existing debate is overly polarised: some studies portray Czechoslovak soldiers in Habsburg service as no less loyal than other nationalities, while others present them as committed nationalists seeking to fight for an independent state from the outset. He acknowledges some existing research that tries to bridge the gap, such as Cornwall (2000), Hutečka (2019),

and Lein (2014); nevertheless, he argues that the right tools to resolve this debate have yet to be applied.

The analysis draws on two individual-level datasets. The first, accessible in detail thanks to the Czechoslovak Legionnaires' Association (n.d.), covers approximately 130,000 Legionnaire records. Each record includes date and place of birth, home municipality and district, education, occupation, Habsburg unit at capture, date and place of Legion enlistment, rank, and the reason and date of separation from the Legions.

The second, compiled by the Central Military Archives of the Czech Republic (n.d.), records fallen Habsburg soldiers with comparable biographical information alongside unit affiliation and date, cause, and location of death. Together, the two datasets make it possible to compare soldiers who deserted to join the Legions with those who remained in Habsburg service until death.

4 Methodological Considerations

As the closest related studies differ in the mechanisms studied, they also differ in the methodology used. Costa and Kahn (2003) use competing-risk hazard models with time-varying covariates, which account for soldiers who exit the sample through death, discharge, or capture before deserting. A Weibull baseline hazard allows the authors to test duration dependence, while time-varying covariates capture how battlefield conditions and company mortality affect desertion risk over the course of service.

Fan et al. (2026) use a panel logit with year fixed effects as their core estimator, with a competing-risk model as a robustness check. Their dataset observes officers annually, and competing exits are rare enough that a binary outcome model suffices. The panel structure exploits within-officer variation in promotion trajectories, controlling for time-invariant officer characteristics that could otherwise confound the relationship between career incentives and desertion.

Rozenas, Talibova, and Zhukov (2024) use linear probability models (LPM) with 25×25 km grid-cell fixed effects as their primary estimator, complemented by a fuzzy regression discontinuity design exploiting discontinuous arrest levels at Soviet administrative borders, estimated via two-stage least squares. With eleven million observations and mean outcomes away from the boundary, LPM and logit marginal effects converge, while the computational cost of logit would be prohibitive.

Ferrara, Dippel, and Heblich (2025) estimate captain fixed effects from a company-week panel, restricting estimation to non-battle weeks to avoid confounding leadership quality with battle selection. Unlike Costa and Kahn (2003), who rely on unit-level variation, the

high-frequency panel allows direct observation of desertion timing, making duration models unnecessary. They then use a staggered event study around the nineteen largest battles of the war to assess whether high-quality captains reduce in-battle desertions, complemented by an instrumental variables (IV) strategy exploiting quasi-random captain deaths as an exogenous source of leadership turnover. The IV addresses the concern that captain reassignments are not random, as better captains may be systematically moved to harder postings, which would downward-bias OLS estimates of leadership quality.

The proposed analysis will build on similar methods, with the choice of estimator depending on data structure and the availability of timing information. If desertion dates are recorded at the individual level, a competing-risk hazard model following Costa and Kahn (2003) would be the natural starting point. If the data are observed at a lower frequency or timing is unreliable, a panel logit or an LPM analogous to Fan et al. (2026) or Rozenas, Talibova, and Zhukov (2024) would be more appropriate. The identification strategy will depend on the sources of variation available in the data, which are currently under exploration. The rich historical context of the Legions may also make event study designs feasible.

Additionally, the analysis seeks to identify nationalist identity as an additional mechanism driving desertion from the Habsburg army. Nationalist sentiment may be proxied by soldier membership in civic organisations such as Sokol, or by the regional density of national revival activists in the soldier home region. The precise proxy remains under development. The analysis will compare the dataset of Legionnaires maintained by Czechoslovak Legionnaires' Association (n.d.) to the fallen Habsburg soldiers (Central Military Archives of the Czech Republic, n.d.).

5 Conclusion

Desertion offers a window into individual decision-making in a group setting under high stakes. The existing literature has identified several mechanisms, but studies relying on conscript armies face a persistent confound. Soldiers who do not desert may do so out of fear rather than genuine loyalty, given that desertion carried the risk of a death sentence.

The proposed study addresses this limitation using previously unused data from the Czechoslovak Legions, a volunteer army. This setting substantially reduces coercion as a confounder. Moreover, the setting makes it possible to separately examine the role of nationalist identity in driving desertion from the Habsburg army and the factors that weakened commitment within the Legions themselves.

Additionally, the topic fills a gap in Czech historiography, identified by Hutečka (2023). The proposed quantitative approach may help resolve the debate that qualitative methods have so far left open. The analysis draws on two datasets of approximately 300,000 individual

soldier records from the Czech Ministry of Defence and the Czechoslovak Legionnaires' Association, which have not been used in economic research to date. If the analysis identifies nationalist identity as a meaningful predictor of desertion, the findings could extend the desertion literature beyond its current focus on leadership, peer effects, and political repression, while also speaking to a broader literature on group loyalty and individual decision-making under high stakes.

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